



RESILIENCE REIMAGINED

A CLIMATE WELLBEING RETREAT FOR YOUNG ENVIRONMENTAL
ADVOCATES



Resilience Reimagined

A Climate Wellbeing Retreat for Young Advocates

Organised by Future Forward Development Initiative



Participants and facilitators at the Resilience Reimagined retreat banner

Background

Across Northern Nigeria, young people continue to lead important climate conversations and community-based interventions despite facing the realities of rising temperatures, environmental degradation, and increasing social pressures.

In Gombe and surrounding communities, many young climate advocates are actively engaged in awareness campaigns, community organising, and environmental action. However, while much attention is placed on climate impact and solutions, very little attention is given to the emotional wellbeing of the people carrying out this work.

Burnout, emotional fatigue, and eco-anxiety are becoming increasingly common among young advocates, yet there are limited safe spaces where they can pause, reflect, and reconnect with themselves and others.

To respond to this need, Future Forward Development Initiative organised Resilience Reimagined: A Climate Wellbeing Retreat for Young Advocates — a two-day gathering designed to centre wellbeing, creativity, reflection, and peer connection within climate action.

Objectives

The project aimed to:

- Create a safe and supportive space for young climate advocates to reflect on their wellbeing
- Encourage conversations around mental health, burnout, and emotional resilience in climate work
- Strengthen peer support and connection among young advocates in Gombe
- Promote creativity and mindfulness as tools for emotional expression and resilience
- Reinforce the importance of integrating wellbeing into sustainable climate action

Activities

The retreat brought together 30 young climate advocates, students, and community members for two days of interactive and reflective engagement.

Day One

Activities focused on reflection, awareness, and open dialogue. These included:

- Welcome and interactive icebreakers
- Mental health and wellbeing session facilitated by a wellness professional
- Group conversations on emotional wellbeing and advocacy fatigue
- Reflective discussions on navigating climate work in challenging environments
- A special virtual wellbeing message from Kat McIntosh of Global Nomads encouraging participants and reminding them they are not alone in the work they do

Participants engaged during Day One sessions

A facilitator addresses participants

Day Two

The second day focused on connection, creativity, and emotional expression through:

- Guided mindfulness and reflection sessions
- Peer support and connection circles
- A relaxed "Sip and Paint" creative session which allowed participants to express themselves in a calm and engaging environment
- Closing reflections and shared takeaways

A participant shares reflections in open discussion

Youth advocate speaks during the retreat



A participant creates a tree-of-life painting symbolising resilience during the Sip and Paint session

Close-up of climate-themed artwork in progress

Participants painting together in the garden



Participants proudly display their completed climate artworks

Results and Impact

The project created meaningful engagement and positive emotional impact among participants.

Key Outcomes

- 30 young climate advocates and students directly engaged
- Increased awareness around mental health and wellbeing in climate advocacy
- Stronger peer relationships and community connection among participants
- Improved understanding of the importance of balancing advocacy with self-care
- Creation of a safe space for emotional expression and honest conversations

Participant Feedback Highlights

Based on post-program evaluation responses:

- 93% of participants said the retreat helped them reflect on their personal wellbeing to a great extent
- 90% said they felt safe and comfortable contributing during sessions
- 87% said the experience changed how they think about balancing climate work and personal wellbeing

- 95% expressed interest in staying connected to a supportive community of advocates

Participants described the retreat as refreshing, needed, and emotionally grounding, particularly because it addressed aspects of advocacy that are often ignored.

Lessons Learned

- Young climate advocates deeply value spaces that prioritise emotional wellbeing and honest conversation
- Creative and informal activities such as reflective art sessions can strengthen participation and openness
- Integrating wellbeing into climate work increases engagement, connection, and sustainability among young people
- There is a growing need for more people-centered climate interventions within underserved communities

Conclusion

Resilience Reimagined demonstrated the importance of creating climate spaces that care not only about impact, but also about the people behind the work.

By centering wellbeing, reflection, and connection, the retreat provided young advocates with tools, support systems, and renewed motivation to continue their climate engagement in healthier and more sustainable ways.

The project reaffirmed that caring for environmental advocates is not separate from climate action — it is essential to sustaining it.

Acknowledgment

Future Forward Development Initiative appreciates the support of the UMI Fund for making this project possible.

We also extend gratitude to all facilitators, volunteers, participants, and partners who contributed their time, energy, and support toward creating a meaningful and safe experience for young climate advocates in Gombe.

— *Future Forward Development Initiative* —